Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Anne Sexton's "After Auschwitz"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of Sexton's poem include

anaphora,
free verse,
hyperbole,
imagery,
litany,
meliorism,
metaphor,
metonymy,
personification (death),
reification (anger),
repetition,
simile,
symbol, and
tone.

The contestant is asked to discuss the persona's attitude regarding humankind. Any response to Sexton's "After Auschwitz" must acknowledge the poem's last line; the last line is essentially a rebuttal of the persona's visceral response to the banality of evil that triumphed at Auschwitz.

The personification of death, with his picking and scratching, might be recognized in terms of his patience while watching humankind prove itself capable of acts of extreme evil. This capacity is presented in the hyperbolic imagery of the Nazi breakfast and in the metaphorical declaration that "Man is a flower / that should be burnt" and the observation that "Man / is a bird full of mud."

The young writer might focus directly on the natural potential of both the flower and bird: beauty, primarily visual; symbolically, fruitful and capable of flying, soaring. That history in the guise of Auschwitz tells differently, "full of mud," is framed by the references/descriptions of death—in very unflattering personification.

The optimism explicit in the persona's "begging" God not to bring about humankind's demise—to not hear her prayer—suggests a deep regard for the potential that is humankind, reflected in her litany of humankind's accomplishments, metonymically represented: sharing, communicating, visiting, and hoping. Hands, "miraculous fingers," are capable of breaking bread, writing poems, creating comfort, and supplicating God, actions in stark contrast to the historical events, past, present, and future, represented by Auschwitz and by death's—humankind's—own dirty fingernails.